

7. Exploring an Underwater World

Penny Howard



Warm-up On 28 August 1988, an unusual sailboat named *Lorcha* stopped at Harbourfront in Toronto, Ontario. For five years, *Lorcha* had been the home for Penny Howard and her younger brother, Peter, and their parents, Fiona and Paul, as they sailed from country to country around the world. The family had started out on their grand adventure on Penny's sixth birthday, 1 July 1983.



When we left Canada, I could already swim like a fish, but I had never learnt how to dive or to go snorkelling, that is, to swim with a mask and a breathing tube. I first wanted to go snorkelling on Buccoo Reef in Tobago, an island in the clear, warm waters of the Caribbean.

Dad showed me how to put on a mask and a snorkel. The mask keeps an airspace around your eyes, which enables you to see clearly through water.

sailboat
reef

a small boat with sails

a line of rocks or sand just above or just below the surface of the sea



The snorkel is simply a curved tube with a mouthpiece. You swim on the surface of the water with your face down and you breathe through the snorkel, which sticks up in the air above the water.

To tell the truth, I was a little scared. What if I could not breathe? But when I looked out over the beautiful, warm, **turquoise** water, I decided it was too good a chance to miss, so I slipped in.

But when I opened my eyes, I was in a different world. I was **amazed** at all the beautiful fish. Red and orange and green and blue and gold and purple creatures swam past, with all kinds of spots, dots, stripes and squiggles.

But there were other, less friendly, underwater creatures. When a mean-looking **barracuda** went by, I swam very close to Mom. It was almost two metres long!

Snorkelling on the surface of the water was fun, but soon I wanted to take a closer look at the fish and **coral**. So I began to learn to dive. The **flippers** I wore helped me swim faster and dive deeper. Soon I was diving down two or three metres.

Peter and I both liked to go snorkelling and dive in the coral reefs and islands just off the coast of Venezuela in South America. Sometimes we caught dinner for the whole family by diving for **conch**. A big shellfish can be as heavy as a log,



turquoise (pronounced 'terk-woice') a bluish green colour
amazed astonished; surprised
barracuda a large tropical sea fish with sharp teeth, that eats other fish and can attack people

coral substance like rock, formed in the sea by groups of particular types of small animals
flippers flat rubber attachments worn on the feet for underwater swimming
conch snail-like creature with a large spiral shell





and Peter, only five, would be spluttering when he finally made it to the surface. Someone usually had to go and help him get the conch into the dinghy before he sank again under its weight.

If I had to select one favourite place to swim, it would be the Galapagos Islands in the Pacific Ocean. All the islands have very tame animals on them.

One day, our guide told us we could go swimming with the sea lions. I was a bit doubtful about this. The slithery creatures looked quite friendly, but a sea lion is as big as a human child and they were swimming around so fast. But after everyone else had slid into the water, I went in too. I had quite a bit of fun, with sea lions coming right up to me, then moving off at the very last minute, just centimetres away.

It was easier to make friends with the sea lions on shore than while swimming with them. I had a long talk with a sea lion who popped out of the water beside a rock I was on. Another sea lion

spluttering
dinghy
sea lions
slithery

(here) making a series of short, unclear noises
a small, open boat
large sea animals found mainly near the Pacific coast
slippery





came ashore to tell Peter and me about how a shark had bitten off his flipper. He had nasty **scars** to back up his story.

By the time we got to the Solomon Islands in the South Pacific, I was a pretty strong swimmer and I felt comfortable diving to about three metres.

One day, someone from another boat asked Mom and Dad to dive for their 'prop' (the propeller for the engine of their **dinghy**). They had dropped it **overboard** in about eight metres of water.

"There's also a nice **triton** shell there," said our friend.

"Hmmm," I thought to myself. I had never dived so deep before, but I took a long breath and swam down and down and down.

Everyone was surprised when I came up, **gasping** for breath—and holding the shell! The shell now sits in my bedroom in Toronto. It reminds me of great adventures in faraway lands. It also tells me that I can do whatever I want to do—if I just try.

scars

marks left on the body after wounds have healed

overboard

over the side of a boat or ship and into the water

triton

sea animal having a large beautifully coloured spiral shell

gasping

taking short, quick breaths through the mouth





Reading

(reading for main ideas)

A. Work in pairs and answer these questions. **COM**

1. What was the name of the sailboat that was the home for the Howard family for five years?
2. When had the family started their grand adventure?
3. Where did it finally stop?
4. Where did Penny first learn to go snorkelling?
5. Who taught Penny how to use a snorkel?

(reading for inference; HOTS)

B. Complete the table. **CT**

Places	What they saw	Things they learnt
Buccoo Reef, Tobago	fish were of many colours with many patterns	snorkelling
	<u>barracuda</u>	
		shellfish are heavy
The Galapagos Islands		
The Solomon Islands		if one tries, one can do anything

C. Think and answer. **CT**

1. What inspired Penny to learn diving?
2. Why did she find the Galapagos Islands the best place to swim in?
3. What does her communication with sea lions tell you about the relationship between human beings and animals? 



D. Discuss in class. **CT** **co-existing in nature**

(value-based question)

There are many skills that the children learnt in this story. Do you think it would have been possible if the children just read about the skills and never put them to practice? Say why.



Using Grammar

(prepositions)

A **preposition** is a word that is used before a noun or a pronoun, connecting it to another word.

The conch lay **below** the dinghy.

Here, **below** tells us where the conch was. It is a **preposition of place**.

The Howard family had been on the sailboat **for** five years.

Here, **for** tells us how long they had been on the sailboat. It is a **preposition of time**.



A. Work in pairs and look at the picture. Underline the right prepositions from the brackets.

1. Mary and Paul are (at/by) the beach.
2. The sun is shining high (over/in) the sky.
3. Clouds are floating (on/in) the sky.
4. The sea is rolling (below/behind) them.
5. The waves dash gently (under/against) the shore.
6. The children are playing (by/in) the sand (with/of) buckets and spades.
7. Paul has a spade (on/in) his hands.
8. There is a beautiful sandcastle (in front of/behind) them.



-  **B. Complete these sentences with prepositions from the box. Use a word only once.**  

in on under with alongside

1. The grand adventure began _____ Penny's sixth birthday.
2. The propeller was dropped _____ about eight meters of water.
3. There was a beautiful world _____ the sea.
4. Penny swam _____ her mother when she saw the barracuda.
5. They went swimming _____ the sea lions.



Using Words

(compound adjectives)

Look at these phrases from the story.

- underwater world
- a mean-looking barracuda

The highlighted words are **compound adjectives**. Each adjective is made up of two words that act as a single adjective to describe a noun.

See how they are formed.

- under + water = underwater
- mean + looking = mean-looking

Note how the words in a compound adjective are sometimes linked together with hyphens.

-  **Work in pairs and complete these sentences with the right compound adjectives from the box.** 

three-week air-conditioned part-time well-known long-haired

1. The _____ computer lab in my school gets really cold.
2. We are going on a _____ holiday.
3. That _____ girl in the photograph is her sister.
4. Her uncle is a _____ artist.
5. The store employs a lot of _____ workers in summer.





Assessment of Speaking and Listening



Listening

(listening to persuasive language)

These two advertisements speak about two tourist spots. Listen to them and fill in the blanks. Discuss your answers with your teacher.

1. Come to the Galapagos Islands for the _____ in the world. The _____ you find here can never be found anywhere else in the world. It has the _____, adventure sports and _____. Play with sea lions or just _____—there is something for everyone here. The islands are like _____ and have a lot to _____!
2. The Solomon Islands—these islands are _____ away from Australia. The islands are like _____ and the sea as clear as _____. It is a _____ and enchanting experience—you will find tritons and fish as bright and colourful as a _____. All _____, such as football, beach ball, snorkelling, diving and Frisbee, are available here and _____. So make your _____ and bring your family for the _____ ever.

Pronunciation

(revision: consonant sounds in kite—goat and fan—vase with familiar vowel sounds)

Remember the sounds you practised. Say these words aloud and revise the sounds.

vast fuss cake mug come gum five



Speaking

(making suggestions)

Imagine you want to start a book club in your school. You want to suggest the idea to your classmates. This is how you could begin.

- **How about** starting a book club?
- **Why don't** we open a book club?
- **Let's** open a book club.

Here are some more phrases you could use.

- We could...
- Could we...
- Can't we...
- I suggest we...

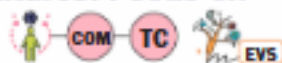
A. Work in pairs. Take turns to make suggestions.



1. You want to have an ice cream with your friend. Make a suggestion.
2. Your sister wants to buy a new bicycle. She wants you to go with her to the store.

(speaking on a topic)

B. Work in pairs. Look at this picture. Take turns to describe it. Observe the different kinds of fish and other colourful sea creatures. Focus on how they look (the colour, special shape if any, etc.).





Take the help of these clues to speak more about them.

- starfish: flat sea animal—shaped like a star—has five arms
- seahorse: small fish—has a head like a horse
- crab: has five pairs of legs—has a round, flat body covered by a shell
- octopus: has a soft oval body—has eight arms
- turtle: lives in or near water—has a thick shell covering its body (into which it can move its head and legs)

Begin like this.

The sea is very colourful and vibrant. There are interesting creatures who live in the sea...



Writing

(writing a diary entry)

Imagine you are Penny. You have had an exciting day when you went deep down into the water to get the triton shell. Write in your diary about what happened.



Begin this way.

(Date, Day)

Dear Diary,

I now know that nothing is impossible! I am a pretty strong swimmer and I used to feel comfortable diving to about three metres. Today, someone from another boat asked Mom and Dad to dive for their prop in about eight metres of water. Our friend...

